Bologna in 3 Days 🇮🇹

Local tips, food & hidden gems from your local hosts

Day 1 — Historic Center & Hidden Bologna

Morning Walk

Jewish Ghetto

Start your day wandering through the tiny medieval alleys of the old Jewish quarter. It's one of the most atmospheric areas in Bologna, full of hidden passages and quiet corners.

The "Finestrella"




The famous little hidden window overlooking Bologna's canals — often called "the little Venice of Bologna."
Best visited early in the morning before it gets crowded.

Piazza Maggiore




The heart of the city. Here you'll find:

- the impressive Basilica di San Petronio
- the Neptune Fountain
- the whispering arches of Palazzo del Podestà (stand in opposite corners and you can hear each other perfectly)
- the archaeological ruins beneath the Salaborsa Library

💡 **Local tip:** enter the Biblioteca Salaborsa for free and look down through the glass floor to see ancient Roman ruins underneath.

Breakfast

RistòPallotti Bologna

Address: Via Irnerio, 17a, 40124 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +390515872536

A classic local pastry shop near the university area.

Opening hours:
Daily from 06:30
Closes around 19:30 (20:00 on Saturdays)

Try:

- pistachio croissant
- cream-filled brioche
- cappuccino

OR

Pappare' Bologna





Address: Via De' Giudei, 2d, 40126 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +390510954088

Perfect if you want a more modern brunch-style breakfast.

Opening hours:
08:00–19:00
(Sundays from 09:00)

Famous for:

- avocado toast
- specialty coffee
- filled croissants
- pancakes

💡 Sit outside if the weather is nice — it’s right in the center.

Lunch

Bottega Portici - 2 Torri




Address: P.za di Porta Ravegnana, 2b, 40126 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +390512964231

Probably the best quick lunch stop in the city.

Opening hours:
08:00–22:00 (Fri–Sat)
08:00–21:00 (other days)

Order takeaway tortellini and eat them with a view of the Two Towers.

Recommended:

- tortellini in parmesan cream
- tortelloni with butter and sage

💡 The seating near Piazza di Porta Ravegnana gives one of the best tower views in Bologna.

Dinner

Va Mo Là





Address: Via delle Moline, 3a, 40126 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +39051237201

A cozy and affordable place for traditional Bolognese cuisine.

Opening hours:
Lunch: 12:00–15:00
Dinner: 19:00–23:30

Try:

- tagliatelle al ragù
- cotoletta alla bolognese
- mascarpone dessert

💡 Reservation recommended for dinner.

Day 2 — San Luca & Shopping

Morning

Sanctuary of San Luca



Walk under the world’s longest portico all the way up to the sanctuary.

💡 Bologna has over 60 km of porticoes and this route is the most iconic.

If you don’t want to walk uphill, you can also take the San Luca Express tourist train.

Best time:

- early morning
- sunset for panoramic views

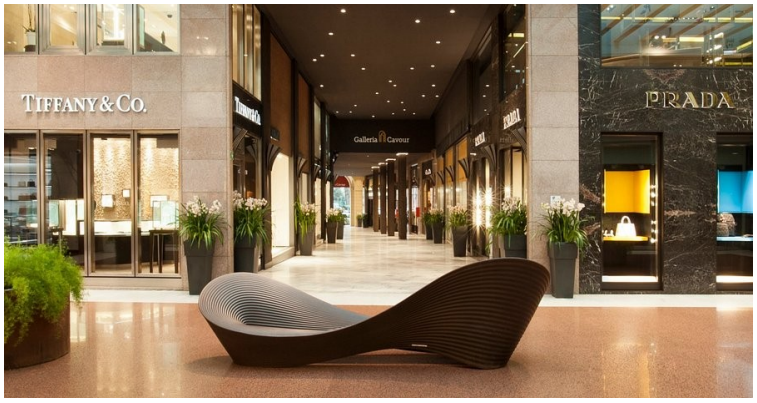
Afternoon Shopping

Via Indipendenza



Main shopping street with both Italian and international brands.

Galleria Cavour



Luxury shopping area with designer boutiques and elegant arcades.

💡 Even if you're not shopping, it's worth entering just to admire the architecture.

Breakfast

Corner Bar





Address: Via Saragozza, 37a, 40123 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +393888186606

Opening hours:
07:30–00:00
(01:00 on Fridays and Saturdays)

Great for:

- gourmet tramezzini
- fresh pastries
- brunch plates

Perfect stop before heading to San Luca.

Lunch

Pizzeria Altero - Via dell'indipendenza





Address: Via dell'Indipendenza, 33c, 40121 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +39051234758

Opening hours:
10:00–23:00 (Saturday)
10:00–22:30 most days

A Bologna institution for cheap and delicious pizza slices.

💡 Order pizza “al taglio” and eat standing like locals do.

Aperitivo / Light Dinner

Osteria delle Donzelle



Address: Via delle Donzelle, 4/3, 40126 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +39051264525

Opening hours:
12:00–15:00
19:00–23:00

Perfect for trying:

- tigelle
- cured meats
- squacquerone cheese
- local wine

💡 One of the most authentic traditional atmospheres in the city center.

Day 3 — Secret Corners & Relaxed Bologna

Morning Walk

Corte Isolani



Look for the mysterious suspended arrows hidden in the wooden ceiling of the courtyard.

💡 According to legend, assassins missed their target and the arrows remained stuck there forever.

Santo Stefano & the Seven Churches



One of Bologna’s most beautiful and peaceful places.

You can explore:

- hidden cloisters
- Romanesque churches
- candle-lit chapels
- medieval courtyards

💡 Locals often call it simply “Le Sette Chiese.”

Afternoon

Giardini Margherita



Bologna’s biggest park — ideal for relaxing after sightseeing.

Le Serre dei Giardini

A beautiful greenhouse café and cultural space inside the park.

Perfect for:

- coffee
- brunch
- cocktails
- reading in the garden

Breakfast

Roxy Bar





Address: Via Rizzoli, 9, 40125 Bologna BO, Italy Phone: +390515060498

Opening hours:
07:30–late
(weekends until around 01:00)

Historic central café on Via Rizzoli.

💡 Great people-watching spot with views toward the Two Towers.

Optional Day Trips 🚆

Riviera Romagnola

About 1 hour away by train.

Best for:

- beach day
- seafood
- nightlife

Recommended towns:

- Rimini
- Riccione
- Cesenatico

Cesenatico



Florence

Only around 40 minutes by high-speed train.

Perfect for:

- Renaissance art
- museums
- shopping
- sunset at Piazzale Michelangelo

Extra Tips & Hidden Gems ✨

Vintage Market

Mercato vintage della montagnola



Address: P.le Camillo Baldi, 40126 Bologna BO, Italy

Open:

- Friday & Saturday
- 09:00–17:00

Great for:

- vintage clothing
- accessories
- leather jackets
- unique souvenirs

💡 Go early for the best finds.

Useful Bologna Tips

- Bologna is very walkable — most attractions are within 20 minutes on foot.
- Porticoes protect you from both rain and sun, so walking is always pleasant.
- Locals usually eat dinner after 8 PM.
- Avoid ordering “spaghetti bolognese” — locals eat **tagliatelle al ragù** instead.
- Climb the Asinelli Tower if you want the best panoramic city view.
- Bologna is famous for:
  - tortellini
  - mortadella

- lasagna verde
- tigelle
- ragù

Enjoy Bologna — it’s one of Italy’s most authentic and underrated cities 🇮🇹